First Congregational Church
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 11
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Compassion

15 November 2026



Iona Hillside – by Rev. Michael Lehman

The compassion of God is for all that has been made. Psalm 145.9

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Improvisation on KINGSFOLD and LAUDA ANIMA
Aeolian Toccata (Jan Pieterszoon Sweelinck)
Élévation in Eb Major (Auguste Durand)
Pièce de Cornet (Thomas Babou)
Meditation on "Come Ye Thankful People" (Dennis Janzer)
WIR PFLÜGEN (Paul Fejko)
Präludium in C (Carl August Kern)
Prelude on FOREST GREEN (Carlos Staszeski)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome **Rev. Michael Lehman**

Words of Gathering **Claire Kelly, Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris**

On this day, Holy One, help us to remember
that all things are born of you.

We carry within us your light and your life.
In the mystery of matter
and deep in the cells of our souls
are your longings for oneness.

The oneness of the universe
vast and vibrating with the sound of its beginning.

The oneness of the earth
greening and teeming as a single body.

The oneness of the human soul
a sacred countenance in infinite form.

On this day, grant us your longings for oneness,
Holy One, amidst life's glorious multiplicities.

[jphilipnewell]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

Hymn of Gathering** ***Praise with Joy the World's Creator LAUDA ANIMA

Praise with joy the world's Creator, God of justice, love, and peace,
Source and end of human knowledge, grace bestowing without cease.
Celebrate the Maker's glory, power to rescue and release.

Praise to Christ who feeds the hungry, frees the captive, finds the lost,
Heals the sick, upsets religion, fearless both of fate and cost.
Celebrate Christ's constant Presence - Friend and Stranger, Guest and Host.

Praise the Spirit sent among us, liberating truth from pride,
Forging bonds where race or gender, age or nation dare divide.
Celebrate the Spirit's treasure - foolishness none dare deride.

Praise the Maker, Christ, and Spirit, one God in Community,
Calling Christians to embody oneness and diversity.
Thus the world shall yet believe when shown Christ's vibrant unity.

***Prayer of Awareness** **Rev. Lehman**

Holy One,
as you open our eyes that we might see the needs of others;
open also our ears, that we may hear their cries;
and our hearts so that they need not be without comfort.

Let us not be afraid to defend the weak because
of the anger of the strong,
nor afraid to defend the poor because
of the anger of the rich.
Show us where love and hope and faith are needed,
and use us to bring them to those places.

And then, Holy One, open us with your compassion
so that in the days to come,
we will be able to do the work
of peace with you, and with each other.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

***Introit** An Affirmation ANDREW CARTER

Commonwealth Youth Choir with Cathedral Choir TEXT: STEPHEN GRELLET
Brandon Harris, *Director of Commonwealth Youth Choir*

I expect to pass through this world but once. Any good thing, therefore, that I can do,
or any kindness I can show, or any service I can render to any soul, of human or animal,
let me do it now. Let me not defer or neglect it, for I shall not pass this way again.

***The Lord's Prayer** **Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris**

Eternal Spirit,
Life-Giver, Pain-Bearer, Love-Maker,
Source of all that is and that shall be.
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name
echo through the universe!

The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.

With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.

For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,
now and forever. Amen.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace** **Rev. Lehman**

Peace in the longing,
peace in the leaving,
peace in the letting go.
In every step, peace.

Today
now
this moment
may we see
the presence of God
in the face of another
and, in our seeing,
may we find life. [adapt/jrichardson]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition **Claire Kelly, Juniper Fayazova & Garfield Morris**

from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 15

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People **Rev. Lehman**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Unfathomable Mystery,
source and substance of all being,
we long to know your presence
in and through our lives.
In our search, we hear you challenge us to work for life that endures,
life that heals the rough and broken places in our lives,
life that takes the pain we carry in our bodies and our hearts,
life that feeds the hunger in ourselves and others for reconciliation.

O God, we are trying to trust
that when we care enough to share ourselves,
there will be enough for all:
enough forgiveness, enough healing, enough compassion.
We hold close to our hearts those we know who are in pain,
and those more distant,
whose lives are heart-wrenching stories in our ears.
O God, together we pray for all those who suffer.

Because of your ever expanding presence,
we continue to be awed by the beauty of your creation.
Our senses overflow with tastes, and smells,
and touch too delicate for words,
and for everyone, who is a precious gift.

We celebrate the rich variety of gifts you offer us in this place,
to build lives with spirituality, community, and justice,
as we work for peace here
and in the many ordinary places of our lives.

This morning, Holy One, hear our prayers of gratitude,
hear our thanks for the richness of the never-ending gifts,
in this marvelous world.

Let us in the days to come,
live our lives as compassionate and generous people,
in all that we do, in all that we are,
and in all we hope to become.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem Recovery Family MOLLY PEASE, TEXT: RANDALL PEASE

Molly Pease, *Vocals*

Our love Above lip buds bloom as if they're moons. Spirits starring, still eyes shining to pass to others As if one mother. One wave As cave When wave breaks, beach they seek. Lip buds bloom as if they're moons. Eternal sea. Our womb. Our tomb.

Sermon ***Sacred Compassion*** **Rev. Laura Vail Fregin**

Invitation to Generosity **Rev. Lehman**

In this time of worship,
here among this gathered people,
we have been given comfort and challenge,
mystery and grace,
to provide for nourishment
each step of our journey.

As people who are truly thankful,
we give from our hearts,
and from our resources to make certain
this place of welcome and belonging
is available for everyone -
whether we come from near or far.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory Abendlied JOSEF RHEINBERGER

Laude

Stay with us, for the night is almost here and the daylight is almost gone

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer** **Claire Kelly**

Thanks be to you, O God,
for the stirrings of new life in us this day,
from rising from the dreams of the night
to a fresh flowing of energy,
for the vitality that awakened our bodies
and the desires that stir our souls.

Let us know the power for life that is in us,
the life-force that is in our senses,
and the might that is within our hearts.

Let us know you as the source of such force
and be wise to its true streams and false currents.

As we leave this sacred time and place,
let us serve love with our strength this day,
let us serve love with our strength.
In heart and mind and body this day,
let us serve love.
[JPhilipNewelladapt/lvf]
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church **Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin**

Words of Blessing **Rev. Fregin**

The blessings of the sun
the blessings of the moon
the blessings of east and west
to guide us on this way
to lighten our eyes
to strengthen our will and our loving.

The blessings of earth
the blessings of air
the blessings of fire and water
to fill us with heaven
to free us with mercy
to stir us with flames of compassion.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!

Choral Response Lean on Me BILL WITHERS, arr. KAYO ANDERSON
Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir

Hymn for the Journey** ***Creator of the Intertwined KINGSFOLD
Creator of the intertwined, you made each soul unique:
Each one with ears to hear faith's call, each one with voice to speak.
Each worships where the call is heard in forest, temple, dome,
On mountain-top, in upper room the soul must find its home.

The song of peace best sung by all, strength born of unity.
In harmony we celebrate Your gift: diversity.
Can we not sing each other's songs? Speak unfamiliar prayer?
Rejoicing in the bounty of the differences we share?

In evil's wake we all are hurt; when pricked, all humans bleed.
With common wounds and shared despair, we seek the balm we need.
We do not ask before we reach to offer our embrace,
We do not ask, "How do you pray?": We reach with arms of grace.

Teach us to cherish what is strange and so the richer be,
To listen with our hearts and speak with loving honesty.
From different sources comfort comes, each seeks for the divine:
Your voice speaks many languages, just one of them is mine.

Postlude **Dr. Christoph Bull,** *Organist-in-Residence*

Allegro Maestoso in G Major (Carlos Staszeski)

Inside The Music

"Exploring *Sacred Compassion* we begin with an Affirmation shared between our Youth and Adults through the simple joy of homophonic choral singing: we affirm that any kindness we can render to one another, *let us not defer or neglect it*. In meditation, Molly shares with us her musical setting of the poetry of her late father which, in her words, "deals with his struggles with depression and addiction through oceanic symbolism." Through Molly's sharing we exercise the muscles of compassion as we consider the hardships experienced in ourselves and others, extending grace and kindness to all that we encounter.

In offertory, Laude shares a staple of the choral canon in Rheinberger's *Abendlied*, singing together in easy harmonies and homorhythmic patterns that we will abide with one another as evening or hardship falls. And in choral response, we sing the arrangement of the Bill Withers classic by our friend Kayo Anderson, founder and director of the Peace and Healing Center Los Angeles– ensuring and affirming that through times of struggle and beyond, on one another we can lean. *Just call on me, sibling, when you need a friend: you just might have a problem that I understand! We all need somebody to lean on."*

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